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KALIBARI NEWS

(Registered Charity 1158269)
Visit us at: www.londonkalibari.org.uk

Kalibari Centre: 18 Byron Road, Wealdstone, Harrow, HA3 7ST
Issue 22, July 2019

From the Trustee Chairman

The next AGM is going to be held on Sunday 14 July at the Kalibari Centre at 3pm. At the AGM, two trustees resign by rotation - they can be re-elected. This year it is the turn of Sudin Mandal and Satya Chatterjee. Both are willing to stand for a further term.
In our Monday Luncheon Club, the food is donated by one member in turn, the others pay a contribution. Items such as tea, coffee, condiments, biscuits, milk are provided free by the members. The contribution is a nominal of £4 per person (increased from £3 since May). Some voluntarily pay more. The money helps to pay for the lease and utilities which is just over £700 per month. The income from donations, receipts from social functions, and Pujas (including Gift Aid refund of tax from HMRC) help to make up for the deficit and add to the Kalibari Building Fund about £12,000 per year.

For your information:
London Kalibari Trustees:
Dr Sudin Mandal (Chair), Mrs Jayati Das (Secretary), Mr Mrinal Choudhury (Treasurer), Mrs Krishna Ghosh, Mrs Debjani Sengupta and Dr Satya Chatterjee

Core Support Group:
Mrs Rama Choudhury, Mrs Gita Dutta, Mrs Babli Mazumdar, Mr Kanu Roy, Mr Snehangshu Basu, Mrs Giti Ray and Mrs Dipti Chatterjee

Do join us in all our activities and enjoy the company of friends.

Bank of Baroda (London Kalibari Banker)
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General Secretary's Report:

Our lease for the present address has been extended to 2022. But with increased rent of £100 per month from October 2018, there is a shortfall in our current monthly income. We have to pay the utility bills, council tax etc. That is the reason we increased our luncheon contributions from £3 to £4. Some new devotees have started to pay monthly by direct debit, but we are still short of £160 per month.

We have lodged a petition against the double yellow lines imposed by the Harrow Council Traffic Committee around our centre. This has caused considerable strain on our ageing members. A few of our members attended the open meeting to voice their feelings. A delegation of Kalibari members have met up with Harrow councillors on this issue.

May Ma Kali keep you safe healthy and happy.

Treasurer's Statement:

a) Income & Expenditure: (approximate - regular per month)

Income –	Standing Order	£290
	Lunch'n Club	£110*
	Donations	£30
	Hall Hire	£40
	Utsav/Events	£100
	Total	£570
Expenditure -	Rent	£600
	Utilities	£95 (Water £35, Gas&Elec. £60)
	Council Tax	£35 (Govt. Relief)
	Total	£730
Shortfall **		£160

* In the Luncheon club (every Monday), one member in turn donates the food and all contributions (nominally £4/person) from other members go to the fund.

** Large donations make up the shortfall and leave a surplus for the Building Fund

b) Long term investment & Cash in bank – ask any trustee

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Recent Events

We are very pleased to report that the Kalipuja on 5 May, conducted by Amiya Bhattacharjee, was a great success. It was very well attended and in fact the Centre reached its absolute capacity after a long time. Many thanks to the sponsors (some members of Kalibari) and the devotees who helped on the day. A large contribution was made to the Kalibari Building Fund.

We are extremely grateful to the regular core group of supporters. Especially Rama Choudhury, Giti Roy, Gita Datta, Dipti Chatterje, Kanu Roy, Millie Basuroy and Arati Thakur whenever we are lucky enough to have her in the UK.

Please see below for the forthcoming events. We are looking forward to seeing you all there. For the Narayan Puja on 21 July, our usual caterer (who also helps with distribution of food) is away; so we are looking for some additional help on this.

Forthcoming Events 2019

- Annual General Meeting (35th): Sunday 14 July at Kalibari Centre at 3pm
- Narayan Pujo: Sunday 21 July in Kalibari Centre (starting at 1pm)
- Janmastami Celebration : Sunday 25 August in Kalibari Centre
- Main Kali Puja /Diwali: Sunday 27 October at Harrow Arts Centre

London Kalibari wishes to thank the following:

1. Supporters and helpers from the Community.
2. Harrow Council for Accommodation and Rate Support.
3. Harrow Art Centre for Diwali/Kalipuja.
4. Mr Navin Shah, GLA Member, Wealdstone Labour Hall, for arranging the rental of the Kalibari Centre.
5. Mr Gareth Thomas, MP for Harrow West, Labour Party for his support.
6. Councillors of Harrow Council for their support and encouragement.
7. Sponsors of Kalibari events & activities.
8. Ms Tanuka Saha, of N. Saha & Co. Chartered Accountants.
9. Mr Avishek Chaudhuri for website.

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A Journey to the Kumbh Mela - Dr Satya Chatterjee
(Part 2 – continued from the last Newsletter)

Dipti and I were at Allahabad station waiting to be picked up by someone from Abichal Maharaj's team who was going to take us to the Kumbh Mela campsite. Eventually two young lads came on a bike and led us to the camp. Young Abichal Maharaj explained that they were allocated the area very late and so everything got delayed. People were working continuously, camps were being built, later a big poster of Vivekananda Samiti was put on near the gate. Several long rooms were made over a rectangular area. Bamboo structure, tin roof, sides were of plastic/ polythene sheets, about 40 feet to 50 feet long and about 25 feet wide, 5-6 rooms were made by fixing bamboo bars at about 7 feet high, plastic sheets as partitions. Plenty of hay was laid on the sand floor. A few rooms had wooden plank cots, for which we had to pay extra 500 rupees. Others were on the floor. 'Toshak' cotton wool filled mattresses were provided also; 'Lep' cotton wool filled duvets were given. Common latrines, a few of them western, bathing areas with taps, open area for men, plastic rounded area for women were erected. Enough of them and plenty of water. The common kitchen would give you hot water and had to be collected. An area in the middle had small plastic tables and chairs for eating. Some members would sit on the ground like in the traditional Indian style. Tea, breakfast of puri sabji, lunch of roti rice dal sabji sweet, same for dinner were provided daily.

During the day when the sun is out, the temperature goes up to about 20-22 degree and as the sun goes down the temperature goes down to about 4-6 degrees. It becomes very cold in the night, the bed seems to become watery. The top of the room is all open like a long attic. All can hear whatever they are talking. The worst thing is that snoring could be heard from everywhere. In the morning we went out for a walk. There were so many people/ pilgrims walking all over. In some places breakfast, lunch and dinner were distributed freely. Many roadside shops selling tea, water bottles, local sweets etc. There were many famous Akhra, where they practice spiritual meditation etc under a Guru. They are normally called Mandaleswar. Where there are 7-9 of them one would be Mahamandaleswar who would guide all. We saw quite a few of Naga (naked) sadhus sitting in their tents. Dipti unfortunately started getting cough and headache. Several years ago she had big operation of her facial sinuses. She was gargling and covering up against cold. But gradually she became worse in the night, continuously coughing and having difficulty in breathing like an asthmatic. I was very worried. One of our roommates, a gentleman from Silchar, would bring hot water in his flask every night.

On 13th we walked to the riverside. It took about 15-20 minutes. People were bathing. A few were getting their heads shaved for the Sraddha ceremony or ' pindadaan '. Two long bridges were seen, one for railway and the other for motor vehicles, they were at a

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distance of 15 meters and 1 km from our camp. Many of the camps were playing music in loudspeakers, religious songs etc. The whole atmosphere felt Holy. After lunch we took naps. In the evening again we walked around. The whole area was very well lit. In the night I gave Dipti my inhaler and special tablet that gave her some relief from cough and spasm.

On 14th Abichal Maharaj told everyone about tomorrow's big day, we would have to leave at 4 am. We went for a walk and took photos. Cold wind was blowing. People were fully dressed in their winter clothes, Sadhus were having blankets. A few Naga sanyasis were in small tents firing woods and all clad with ash all over their body. On the road I met with a Sanyasini, lady sadhu who allowed me to take her photo with her right hand raised in a blessing fashion. In the evening I went for a stroll and saw a big camp where Ramlila was being performed on a stage. On my way back I saw many ' Bhandara 's offering dinner with many different delicious items. I controlled my temptation and returned to camp.

15 January at 4 am about 300 of us gathered on the road. The destination was about 5-6 kilometres. Very cold and little windy, bright lights all around. We were told to make two lines and we followed Abichal Maharaj who was walking in front. After 10 minutes walk we entered into another big camp. At about 5 am our Mandaleswar Swami came out. I think he was in his late 50's, bright face and eyes, black beard, wearing saffron robes. He started walking in front of us, his close disciples holding a big golden umbrella over his head. There were many thousands of people on the road. Police were controlling, there were military guards as well. Some Naga sanyasis were almost running and the police were escorting them. I saw 1 or 2 white Europeans among them.

Our movement was an easy pace. Our Mandaleswar was holding mobile phone at his ear for instructions. Gradually we went on a road beside a pontoon bridge and waited. Huge crowd all over as far as we can see - a sea of pilgrims and people were running here and there. The movement was controlled centrally and we waited for our turn. One of our elderly men, in mid 80s, fell ill and fainted. He was taken to a tent nearby and he recovered fortunately. There were trucks well decorated with red clothes, golden glistening materials etc and a throne was created above in the middle. At about 7 am our Mandaleswar swami climbed up to the throne. It was pulled by a tractor engine. Close disciples and followers climbed and sat around. All other Mandaleswars waiting nearby also climbed to their positions. This bridge is the only one meant to be used for crossing the river Ganga for going to the Sangam. In about half hour 's time the Naga Sanyasis were allowed to go on the bridge. They were the ones who would go first. They were in thousands, chanting Ganga Mai Ki Jai, Hara Hara etc, waiving tridents, one or two with swords, they were almost running guarded by police on both sides of the bridge. After them the Mandaleswars started moving and going to the bridge.

Ms Tanuka Saha
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Mill Hill, London NW7 4RN (London Kalibari Accountant)

www.nsaha.co.uk Telephone 020 8906 8855

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We crossed the bridge slowly. Several roads were made by putting bamboo barriers. About 2 km we have to walk. Thousands of people behind the barriers watching, cameramen, news readers, were all on the sides. All were watching and shouting, encouraging us the Pilgrims. I felt so happy in my mind. I thought there must be a reason for the tradition to carry on by so many Sadhus, sanyasi, mahatma people etc. As we were approaching the Ghat or main bathing shore we saw the Sanyasis returning running passing us. At the meeting place Ganga flows from left and Yamuna comes from the right. There was pandemonium, chaos you name it. The whole area was spread with hay. Near the end it was all wet as people were coming up with wet bodies. It felt like when two three trains come at big railway station and passengers try to go first through the gate and there are so many at one place body to body similar to that.

We five from our room were together all the time, found a dry place. We decided Dipti and I and the other lady would go for the ‘ dip ‘ first while other two gents would guard our clothes. We went through the crowd and proceeded to the edge, nothing else was coming in the mind but to finish the dip somehow. The edge was slippery, several cement or sand bags were kept, no actual steps were made. I dropped in the water, very cold, dipped twice but third one I sprinkled water on my head. It was waist high deep there. Dipti left my hand and went further out and dipped three times. Then I helped other lady to dip. Someone helped to pull me up and I helped others to get up. The whole thing took about a minute or two as everyone was quick, shivering with cold. We came to our place and changed. No separate place for changing. No one is looking at you. All are busy with themselves. Then other two gents went for bathing. One of them brought a plastic can full of the Holy water from the Sangam.

We slowly started walking back to our camp. Roads were very congested and traffic jam. We could see the rail bridge from a distance, that is where our camp is but about 3 km to walk back, we have already crossed the bridge. We then discovered passages behind the camps, and avoided the main roads to reach our camp. In the afternoon I went out and saw two Naga Sanyasis at their different tents. One blessed touching with a bunch of peacock feathers, the other one put a ‘ tip ‘ or tika of ash on my forehead. They were sitting, I had to put the rupee note, as donation, on the folded bare knee. In the evening again Dipti was not quite right. We planned to leave on 16th. But as a rule on 14th, 15th & 16th no conveyance is allowed except emergency ones. I asked Abichal Maharaj if he would kindly allow his vehicle to drop us at Allahabad city. He instructed one of his employees who agreed but for some more money. Then we contacted our niece at Lucknow who told us that they would drive to Allahabad and collect us. On 16th January we packed our luggage and bid farewell to our friends and left after breakfast. We were dropped and picked up near the station. From Lucknow we came to Kolkata on 19th by Indigo. That is another story.

Community Corner

Order of British Empire (OBE):

Harrow resident Arnab Dutt has been awarded an OBE for his contribution to Small and Medium Size Business in the Queen's Birthday Honours List. Many people of Harrow know him as the son of the Late Bhaskar Dutt and Mrs Monika (Victoria) Dutt. Kalibari wish to celebrate this news along with other members of the Indian Community.

Swami Vivekananda Statue In Harrow Arts Centre: (Update)

The local community at large and Harrow Council have made progress towards the completion of the project. The sculpture by Tom Nicholls of London SE1 is coming to completion. Nearly 60% of this work is done. So far financial contributions from members of the local community have helped towards the project. Now Bank of Baroda and ICCR (Indian Council for Cultural Relations) have also promised to help financially. The project needs further help for completion. Please contact Mrinal Choudhury, 07803083106 or 020 8907 5946 for details.

Sri Aurobindo Society (U.K.):

Harrow is a place of diverse communities and is a base for the activities of this society. It has the Sri Aurobindo Society Centre at 149 Eastcote Lane, South Harrow, HA2 8RR. The Society owns the Centre which is a detached building and has a meditation room and a library. It is open for meditation every Saturday and Sunday from 5pm to 6pm. It is open on other special days such as 1 January, 21 February, 15 August. For more information, please contact 020 8422 9920 or look on the website: www.sriaurobindosocietyuk.org

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London Kalibari Cummunity Centre Project

London Kalibari is an organisation representing the Hindu Bengalee Community in the UK. It is a democratic organisation with a constitution and is a charity registered in 1982 and converted into a Charitable Incorporated Organisation (CIO) in 2014. It has raised funds for the Community Centre Project through many social and cultural activities.

Our aim is to establish a permanent Community Centre in which social, cultural and spiritual activities can be held regularly. In the meantime, we have acquired a rented accommodation at **18 Byron Road, Harrow, Wealdstone, HA3 7ST**, which has a main hall, two smaller rooms, kitchen and two toilets. The Centre is used for the following regular activities:

- Luncheon Club on Monday at midday
- Historical and spiritual talks
- Family counselling services and social ceremonies.

We have also celebrated Kali Puja and Narayan Puja throughout the year which have been very well attended. We have also held an Art Exhibition which was something different from our usual offerings and was enjoyed by all.

A suitable larger property is estimated to cost around one million pounds. A smaller property of the sort we are currently using will cost up to £500,000 with suitable alterations. Of course, in the interim, if the current Kalibari premises were offered for sale, Kalibari would consider purchasing it. We are making efforts to obtain external funding and sponsorships, but significant monies will have to be raised from the community. London Kalibari has a Building Fund of around £190,000 and a number of members have donated £1,000 each and pledges have also been made. We hope you can support us in this worthy cause.

Contacts:

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